

THE KESTREL FILES · A STORY IN SIX MOMENTS

Week 38

You inherit a chip project on Monday morning. By Thursday you are holding six problems at once, and every one of them is work you became a PM to get past.

TAPE-OUT IN 14 DAYS

12-minute read, then 5 minutes with your case file

Pre-work · PM Summit 2026 · PM Role in an AI World

Every name, company, number and date in this story is invented.

01 · 12 MIN

Read the story. It is one week in the life of a PM, and probably one you have lived.

02 · 5 MIN

Open the case file with your room's letter (C1 to C6, in your invitation) and read it like a PM on Thursday morning.

03 · 2 MIN

Note what doesn't add up, and one real moment when this pain cost you time.

08:12

PROLOGUE · MONDAY · CW38

The handover

TAPE-OUT IN 14 DAYS

The coffee machine on floor 3 is broken again, so you start your first day as KESTREL's project manager with a paper cup of something brown from the ground floor and a calendar that someone else has already filled.

Jonas left on Friday. He didn't leave the company; he moved to a program two buildings over that needed him more urgently than KESTREL did, which tells you something about KESTREL, or about the other program. You aren't sure which yet. His handover was a 25-minute Teams call, most of it spent on a camera that wouldn't start, and a folder called KESTREL_handover_FINAL_v3. On the monitor he no longer uses there is a yellow note:

"Everything's in the folder. The lessons file is in there too. Nobody reads it. Good luck with Customer Alpha. J."

Here is what you know. KESTREL is a new sensor-hub chip and the evaluation kit that goes with it. Its lead customer, Customer Alpha, has a design-in window that closes at the end of the year. Win it, and KESTREL becomes the reference part for a whole product family. Tape-out is in calendar week 40, fourteen days from now.



The road to customer samples, in calendar weeks

Here is what you don't know yet. By Thursday morning you will be holding six problems at once, and none of them will be exotic. Every PM you know has had this week.

You open your inbox. Forty-seven unread.

11:04

CHAPTER 1 • MONDAY

Can we do this?

Room card C6 • Change Request Ripple

Sofia's message arrives with a subject line in capitals.

From: Sofia (Product Marketing)

Subject: FW: CR-014 • URGENT • Can we do this??

Customer Alpha has a tech day in week 48. They want samples in week 47 instead of week 50, and they want the evaluation kit to show an “ultra-low-power standby” mode on stage.

“They need an answer this week,” Sofia writes. “Big opportunity. Can you confirm?”

You open the plan. Tape-out, then five weeks in the fab, then first samples in week 46.

Testing them needs a load board that, you now discover, the vendor has just moved from week 41 to week 43. Qualification starts in week 48. The software team that owns the evaluation kit is at half capacity until week 44. And somewhere in a design document you haven't read yet is a line saying the chip's ROM content is frozen at tape-out.

Can we do this? You genuinely don't know. The honest answer lives in seven heads: Design, Verification, Test, Software, Quality, Operations and Marketing. You start typing the first of seven emails, each asking roughly the same question in a slightly different way, and you already know how this goes. The answers will come on Thursday, in seven formats. Two of them will say “depends”. One will never arrive.

Customer Alpha is waiting. So is your 11:30.

Case file C6 • CR-014 and the plan →

16:30

CHAPTER 2 • MONDAY

The log nobody touched

Room card C3 • The Silent Risk

Between meetings you finally open the RAID log. *Last updated: CW33*. Five weeks ago.

Three risks, one issue, one dependency, and a status column that reads more like a memory than a measurement.

R2, load board vendor capacity, was closed in week 30. You scroll back through your chats. Priya, last week: the vendor's test line is "overbooked again". D1, Customer Alpha's use-case spec, was due in week 36. Sofia, two weeks ago: "soon, they're reorganizing." Chen, this morning, in passing: the supplier has moved your substrate order to their next allocation cycle, but it "should still be fine". Daniel, with good news for once: the qualification lab has confirmed your week-48 slot. Lukas has reported the broken coffee machine as a productivity risk.

At 22:10 your phone lights up. Aiko's design team is working its third weekend in a row. There is a sentence about a colleague and some constraints back in July that you read twice and decide not to forward to anyone.

Nobody hid anything from you today. Everything was said, somewhere. It just never became a risk that anyone owns. You wonder how many of the surprises waiting in week 46 are already sitting in your chat history.

Case file C3 · RAID log and two weeks of messages →

10:00

CHAPTER 3 · TUESDAY

Did we decide that?

Room card C2 · Meetings Without Memory

The weekly sync. Seven people, one of them on a train. You chair and take notes at the same time, which means you do both badly.

Aiko: three timing paths are still failing on the power-management block. She thinks they'll close by Wednesday; if not, "we need to talk about options." Sofia wants to propose to steering that you keep week 40 "no matter what". Daniel isn't comfortable with that without a quality view. You hear yourself say "let's not decide that here," and ask Aiko for a status on Wednesday evening so you can prepare options for Thursday's steering meeting.

Priya: the load board is late, week 43 now. "Someone needs to check with the vendor." Everyone agrees it's important. Nobody says who. Lukas checks that the SDK only goes to Customer Alpha after the quality review, and Daniel confirms and promises the review "by end of next week". Chen mentions, quietly, that he is out for two weeks from the 3rd for a family reason, and that his cover isn't confirmed. And almost as an afterthought you decide something real: from now on, every evaluation kit shipment gets an export-control check before it leaves the building.

Forty-eight minutes. At 10:49 you are already in the next call. The transcript sits in the meeting chat, two thousand words long. By Friday somebody will ask, “Did we decide that?” and you will not be sure.

Case file C2 · the sync transcript →

15:45

CHAPTER 4 · WEDNESDAY

Still green?

Room card C1 · Status Report Treadmill

Management wants the weekly status by Friday noon. Last week’s report said GREEN, in Jonas’s confident formatting.

The inputs arrive the way they always do. Aiko’s came by email on Monday, written before anyone knew how Wednesday would go. Marco, in chat: 92% coverage against a target of 95. Priya, by email: test program development “on track”, and in the next sentence, the load board now expected in week 43. Lukas, in chat: SDK beta done, party emoji, and “FYI” a clause from Customer Alpha’s contract about a demo and a penalty that legal is still reviewing. Daniel needs samples by week 46 to start qualification in 48. Chen: “No issues.” Sofia: nothing. You send a reminder. Then another.

The milestone tracker still shows *First samples + test ready* in week 46, unchanged. You look at it for a long time.

Is KESTREL still green? You could copy last week’s report, change the date and move on. People do. Or you could reconcile six inputs in three formats, one missing voice and a tracker that may no longer tell the truth, and then write it all three times: once for the team, once for management and once, very carefully, for the customer. That is your Wednesday evening. It was Jonas’s too, every week, for a year.

Case file C1 · this week’s status inputs →

21:37

CHAPTER 5 • WEDNESDAY

Five opinions, one page

Room card C4 • Decision Brief in 30 Minutes

From: Aiko (Design lead) • 21:37
Subject: PMU • not closed

A clean fix needs three more weeks. Or you tape out on time and repair it later with a metal-layer respin, about six weeks after first samples. Aiko recommends the delay.

By 22:30 you have five opinions and a steering meeting at 14:00 tomorrow. Sofia: the customer's design-in window closes at year end; "if we are late, they will walk away." Daniel: qualifying silicon with a known issue means qualifying it all over again after any fix. Chen: a respin mask set costs about €180k; a three-week slip costs nothing directly, but it loses the wafer start slot, and the next slot is two weeks later. Lukas: a firmware workaround might hide the problem in low-power mode. Two weeks of work, not validated. Your remaining budget reserve is €150k.

Steering doesn't want five opinions. They want the options, the impacts, a clear ask and your recommendation, on one page. Everyone has told you what they think. Nobody has told you what it adds up to. That part is your job.

It is 22:41.

Case file C4 • the decision inputs →

06:50

CHAPTER 6 • THURSDAY

The file nobody reads

Room card C5 • Lessons Nobody Learns

You wake before the alarm. Because you can't face the brief yet, you open Jonas's folder and, for the first time, the lessons file.

Four past projects: HERON, OSPREY, PLOVER, WREN. Ten lessons, written by tired people at the end of something.

ATE hardware ordered after tape-out arrived five weeks late. You think of your load board.
Customer samples shipped before qualification caused two escalations. You think of CR-014.
SDK released without quality review led to customer-found bugs. You think of Tuesday. *Export-control classification done late blocked shipments for three weeks.* You think of the decision you made almost by accident.

There is a lesson about a tool the company retired last year, and another about a test engineer called John that is less a lesson than a grudge. Two lessons disagree completely about shipping early samples.

Somebody learned all of this the hard way, more than once. What if this file had found you on Monday morning, at the moment you needed it, instead of sitting in a folder?

Case file C5 · the lessons file →

07:30

EPILOGUE · THURSDAY

Before the first coffee

TAPE-OUT IN 11 DAYS

This is your Thursday, and it hasn't started yet:

- ☐ A one-page decision brief for steering at 14:00C4
- ☐ A status report that may or may not be green, due tomorrowC1
- ☐ An answer to Customer Alpha about CR-014C6
- ☐ Minutes from Tuesday that nobody has sentC2
- ☐ A risk log five weeks out of dateC3
- ☐ Ten lessons you found three days too lateC5

None of this is the job you were hired for. That job is getting a team of smart, tired people to a good decision, on time. This is the work that stands between you and it.

On 5 November your breakout room takes one moment from this week. In sixty minutes you will design an AI assistant that would have given you that moment back, test it on the

KESTREL case file, and see whether it catches what a careful PM would catch. Every decision stays yours. The assistant takes the rest.

By the end, your room will have a pilot that someone runs on a real project the week after the summit.

WHO'S WHO ON KESTREL

The people in your week

YOU

You · Project manager

New to KESTREL since Monday.
Inherited a folder and a sticky note.

JO

Jonas · Previous PM

Moved to another program on Friday. Reachable, in theory.

AI

Aiko · Design lead

Precise, calm, tired. Her team is on its third weekend.

MA

Marco · Verification

Speaks in percentages. Currently 92 against a target of 95.

PR

Priya · Test engineering

Optimist. Everything is “on track” until the next sentence.

LU

Lukas · Software and tools

Ships fast, types faster, uses emoji in contract discussions.

DA

Daniel · Quality

“Not comfortable” is his strongest word, and he means it.

CH

Chen · Operations

Says “all fine” about most things. Away from the 3rd.

SO

Sofia · Product marketing

Owns Customer Alpha's patience. Silent on status reports.

BEFORE 5 NOVEMBER • ABOUT 20 MINUTES

Your pre-work

1 Read the story.

You just did, or you're about to. Twelve minutes.

2 Open your room's case file.

Your invitation gives your room a letter, C1 to C6. Read that file as if it were Thursday morning and the problem were yours.

3 Find what doesn't add up.

Every case file hides at least two things a careful PM would catch. Write down what you spot and keep it to yourself. In the room you'll find out whether your assistant catches them too.

4 Bring one real moment.

When did this pain last cost you time, and roughly how much per week? Two sentences are enough. Please don't bring confidential documents.

No AI experience needed. Rooms mix beginners and experienced users on purpose, and everyone gets a role.

The case files

These are the mails, chats, logs and notes behind each chapter, exactly as they reached your desk. CW means calendar week.

C1

Still green?

Status Report Treadmill · Chapter 4

C2

Did we decide that?

Meetings Without Memory · Chapter 3

C3

The log nobody touched

The Silent Risk · Chapter 2

C4

Five opinions, one page

Decision Brief in 30 Minutes · Chapter 5

C5

The file nobody reads

Lessons Nobody Learns · Chapter 6

C6

Can we do this?

Change Request Ripple · Chapter 1



Still green?

Status Report Treadmill · the inputs for Friday’s status, CW38

Everything that reached you for this week’s status report, plus the tracker export and last week’s summary.

At least two things here don’t add up. Find them before the summit.

Email · Aiko, Design leadMon

Hi, design status: timing closure on the PMU block still open, 3 paths failing, team working the weekend. Everything else frozen. Should be OK for tape-out CW40 if we close by Wednesday.

Email · Priya, Test EngineeringTue

Test program development on track. Waiting for the load board from the vendor, now expected CW43 (vendor delay).

Email · Daniel, QualityTue

Qualification plan approved. Need samples by CW46 latest to start qualification CW48.

Chat · status channelMon–Wed	
Marco Verification	Regression at 92% coverage, target is 95 before tape-out. 2 new bugs this week, both low.
Lukas Software/Tools	Eval kit SDK beta done 🎉. Also FYI Customer Alpha's contract says we owe them a demo of low-power mode at their November tech day, legal is still reviewing the penalty clause.
Chen Operations	Substrate order confirmed. No issues.

No update received from Sofia, Product Marketing.

MILESTONE	BASELINE	FORECAST	OWNER
Design freeze	CW34	CW34 (done)	Aiko

MILESTONE	BASELINE	FORECAST	OWNER
Tape-out	CW40	CW40	Aiko
Load board ready	CW41	CW43	Priya
First samples + test ready	CW46	CW46	Priya
Qualification start	CW48	CW48	Daniel
Customer sampling	CW50	CW50	Sofia

Last week's status · CW37, by Jonas
Overall: GREEN. Schedule: GREEN. Top risk: PMU timing closure.

C2 Did we decide that?

Meetings Without Memory · weekly sync, Tuesday CW38

The auto-transcribed excerpt of Tuesday's sync, as it sits in the meeting chat.

At least two things here don't add up. Find them before the summit.

PM	OK, let's start. Aiko, timing closure?
Aiko	Three paths still failing on the PMU. We think we can close by Wednesday. If not, we need to talk about options.
PM	What's the fallback if Wednesday doesn't work?
Aiko	Honestly, either we slip tape-out or we tape out and fix it in a metal respin.
Sofia	Slipping is really hard for Customer Alpha. Let's propose to steering that we keep CW40 no matter what.
Daniel	I'm not comfortable with that without a quality view.
PM	OK, let's not decide that here. Aiko, send me the status Wednesday evening and I'll prepare options for steering on Thursday.
Aiko	Will do.
Priya	The load board is late, CW43 now. Someone needs to check with the vendor whether they can expedite.
PM	Yes, that's important.
Lukas	Quick one: SDK beta is out. We agreed last week to release it to Customer Alpha only after the quality review, right?
Daniel	Right, that's still the plan. I can do the review by end of next week.
PM	Good. Chen, anything?
Chen	All fine. By the way, I'm out from the 3rd for two weeks, family matter, my mother is in hospital.
PM	Sorry to hear that. Who covers operations?
Chen	I'll ask Ravi, not confirmed yet.
PM	One more thing. From now on, every eval kit shipment needs an export-control check before it leaves. That's decided. Operations, please implement.
Chen	OK.
PM	Thanks all, same time next week.



The log nobody touched

The Silent Risk · RAID log and two weeks of messages

The RAID log as Jonas left it, and everything said in mail and chat over the last two weeks.

At least two things here don't add up. Find them before the summit.

ID	TYPE	DESCRIPTION	PROB	IMPACT	OWNER	STATUS
R1	Risk	PMU timing closure may not be achieved before tape-out	M	H	Aiko	Open
R2	Risk	Load board vendor capacity	L	M	Priya	Closed CW30
R3	Risk	Qualification lab slot availability CW48	M	M	Daniel	Open
I1	Issue	SDK documentation behind schedule	-	L	Lukas	Open
D1	Dependency	Customer Alpha to provide use-case spec by CW36	-	M	Sofia	Open

RAID log · last updated CW33

Mail and chat · CW36 to CW38

Priya CW37	Vendor says the load board is now CW43, their test line is overbooked again.
Chen CW38	FYI the supplier moved our substrate order to their next allocation cycle. They say it "should still be fine".
Sofia CW36	Customer Alpha's spec will come "soon", they're reorganizing.
Marco CW38	Two new low-severity bugs, nothing blocking.
Lukas CW37	Lol, the coffee machine on floor 3 is broken again, productivity risk!
Daniel CW38	Lab confirmed our CW48 slot.
Aiko CW38	Team is doing another weekend. Third in a row. Honestly, if Tom had done the constraints right in July we wouldn't be here.



Five opinions, one page

Decision Brief in 30 Minutes · tape-out timing, steering Thursday CW38

What you have at 22:41 on Wednesday to build tomorrow's one-page brief.

At least two things here don't add up. Find them before the summit.

Decision needed · tape-out timing

Steering Thu 14:00

PMU block timing closure is still failing on 3 paths (as of Tuesday CW38). Tape-out is planned for CW40.

Aiko · Design

A clean fix needs 3 more weeks. Alternative: tape out on time and fix it later in a metal-layer respin ("metal fix"), which takes about 6 weeks after first samples. Recommends delaying tape-out by 3 weeks.

Sofia · Marketing

Customer Alpha's design-in window closes at the end of the year. "If we are late, they will walk away." Recommends keeping CW40.

Daniel · Quality

Qualifying silicon with a known timing issue means requalification after any metal fix. Concerned about taping out on time.

Chen · Operations

Metal-fix respin mask cost is approx. EUR 180k. A 3-week slip costs nothing directly but loses our wafer start slot; the next slot is 2 weeks later.

Lukas · Software

A firmware workaround could mask the issue, in low-power mode only. About 2 weeks of effort. Not validated.

Constraints

Remaining budget reserve: EUR 150k.
Customer sampling committed for CW50.



The file nobody reads

Lessons Nobody Learns · Jonas’s lessons file and KESTREL’s next phase

The lessons-learned extract from Jonas’s folder, and the profile of the phase KESTREL is about to enter.

At least two things here don’t add up. Find them before the summit.

ID	PROJECT	LESSON AND ACTION
L01	HERON (2023)	ATE hardware ordered after tape-out arrived 5 weeks late; first-sample testing slipped. Action: order test hardware at design freeze.
L02	HERON (2023)	Qualification lab booked 4 weeks ahead was not enough in Q4. Action: book 10+ weeks ahead for Q4.
L03	HERON (2023)	Customer samples shipped before qualification start caused 2 customer escalations. Action: agree sample status (engineering vs qualified) in writing.
L04	OSPREY (2022)	Weekly status via the PMtrack tool was ignored by management. Action: use PMtrack dashboards.
L05	OSPREY (2022)	Late spec changes from the lead customer caused 2 respins. Action: freeze the customer spec with sign-off before design freeze.
L06	OSPREY (2022)	Test engineer John was unresponsive and caused delays.
L07	PLOVER (2024)	SDK released without quality review led to customer-found bugs. Action: gate SDK releases on quality review.
L08	PLOVER (2024)	Export-control classification of eval kits done late blocked shipments for 3 weeks. Action: classify eval kits at the kit design review.
L09	WREN (2024)	Single-source load board vendor; capacity crunch in Q3. Action: qualify a second vendor or reserve capacity early.
L10	WREN (2024)	Early engineering samples built customer trust and won the design-in. Action: ship early engineering samples with clear errata.

Entering phase “tape-out to customer sampling” (CW40 to CW50).

Known pressure points: test hardware timing, qualification slot, lead-customer expectations, SDK release, eval kit shipments.

Note: the PMtrack tool was retired in 2025.



Can we do this?

Change Request Ripple · CR-014 from Customer Alpha

Sofia’s forwarded change request, the part of the plan it touches, and the people you would have to ask.

At least two things here don’t add up. Find them before the summit.

Change request CR-014 · from Customer Alpha via Sofia (Marketing)

Mon CW38

Request 1: Pull in customer samples from CW50 to CW47 (their tech day is in CW48).

Request 2: Add an "ultra-low-power standby" mode to the evaluation kit, demonstrable at the tech day.

Plan excerpt · dependencies

Tape-out CW40 → wafer fab (5 weeks) → first samples CW46

First samples + load board (now CW43) → test program on ATE → samples tested

Qualification start CW48 (6 weeks)

Customer sampling CW50 (engineering samples)

Eval kit software: SDK beta done CW37 → quality review CW39 → SDK 1.0 CW45

Chip ROM content is frozen at tape-out (CW40).

FUNCTION	CONTACT	NOTE
Design	Aiko	
Verification	Marco	
Test	Priya	
Software	Lukas	Team at 50% on another project until CW44
Quality	Daniel	
Operations	Chen	

FUNCTION	CONTACT	NOTE
Marketing	Sofia	

KESTREL does not exist. Its problems, unfortunately, do.

Pre-work for the PM Summit 2026 breakouts, Workstream 2 · PM Role in an AI World · draft v0.1.
Every name, company, number and date in this story is invented.